

The Serpent's Coil

By Crom! A Tale of Sorcery, Serpents, and Stubborn Heroes

A Fate's Edge Adventure for Seasoned (Tier II) Characters

What the Bards Will Sing

"Let me tell you of the time we saved a city from a snake-cult, mostly by accident."

— Szik the Swift, after his seventh ale

ADVENTURE OVERVIEW

@ll Sessions: 3

Themes: Sword & sorcery, cosmic horror, rising legend (whether you want it or not)

Notable Innovation: Heroes become alarmingly powerful while remaining remarkably dense

Patron of the Piece: Isoka, the Angel of Serpents (she's not sure about this plan either)

INTRODUCTION: A NIGHT AT THE BLACK GOAT

The streets of Midh Ahkaz run with fear, though nobody will admit it. A serpent cult has grown fat on whispered promises, and the Governor's Palace now houses something that doesn't cast a proper shadow. The heroes—whatever combination of muscle, blade, and questionable morals brought them together—are about to stumble into the middle of it.

Note to the wise: The heroes in this tale are not the sharpest swords in the armory. They solve problems with axes, miss clues until they trip over them, and tend to believe the first explanation offered. Play them with affection. A heavy brow and a trusting nature are their own kind of courage.

SESSION 1: A SIMPLE JOB (WHAT COULD GO WRONG?)

Opening Hook

The stench of cheap ale and unwashed bodies assaults your nostrils as you push through the sagging door of The Black Goat tavern. Smoke from a dozen pipes creates a choking fog, while the acrid smell of fear hangs thick in the air. In the flickering light of oil lamps, you see him: an ancient Ykrul chieftain, his weathered face creased with desperate worry, clutching a purse heavy with gold coins that clink like a death knell. "They took her," he whispers. "My Yara. Said she'd become the cornerstone of some... serpent age."

GM's note: The chieftain's name is Orun of the Grey Ash. He is sincere, but he's also been drinking. His description of events may be slightly exaggerated. That's fine. The heroes won't notice.

The Black Goat Investigation (Insight + Deception)

- **Success:** You learn that guards have been moving strangely, too fluid, and several people have "disappeared" after being taken to the High City. You also notice one patron's neck has a few odd scales.
- **Partial:** You get the same information, but you also accept a drink from a stranger. It's fine. Probably.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** Each SB generated here adds a point of **Serpent's Favor**—a resource the GM tracks secretly. The player feels a shiver of strange luck.

Temple of Open Sky Visions (Spirit + Lore)

- **Success:** You see serpents coiling around the city's heart, hear whispers of transformation, and taste bitter corruption. This is ominous. You tell the others. They nod wisely and then forget half of it.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** On a Miss or Partial, the character gains 1 Fatigue and 1 Serpent's Favor. The visions are exhausting, but also... exciting? The hero feels strangely drawn to the serpent imagery.

City Approach (Various Skills)

- Midh Ahkaz looms before you like a hungry beast. The gates are reinforced with iron that gleams like fangs. A curfew has been imposed, and the streets are empty. Your forged passage papers feel sticky with something suspiciously red.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** Each SB generated advances the **City Corruption [4]** timer and grants 1 Serpent's Favor. These little strokes of luck feel like fate smiling—but whose?

Discovery (The Obvious Truth They Will Miss)

The city is clearly infested with cultists. There are serpent motifs everywhere, and a child points at a guard and shouts, "He has a snake tongue!" The heroes will likely assume this is a metaphor. It is not.

Timers

- **City Corruption [4]:** How much the serpent influence has spread.
- **Cult Ascendancy [6]:** How close the ritual is to completion.

SESSION 2: BREAKING AND ENTERING (BUT FOR A GOOD CAUSE)

Escalation

The Governor's Palace is supposed to be impressive. It is—in the way a coiled viper is impressive. The walls are carved with serpent motifs that seem to writhe in torchlight. Inside, the hallways bend in ways that hurt the head. A barbarian might conclude, "Bad architecture." That's valid.

The Obvious Choices (Any of Which the Heroes Will Overcomplicate)

- **Bash the door down:** Works every time.
- **Sneak in through the sewers:** Smelly but effective.
- **Pretend to be cultists:** Requires not laughing when you hiss your passwords.

Palace Penetration (Melee or Stealth)

- The guards move too fluidly, their armor gleaming with an oily sheen. Their eyes are all black. A smart person would reconsider. The heroes charge anyway.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** Characters with 3+ Serpent's Favor find this encounter **Dominant**. Each SB generated adds 2 segments to City Corruption and grants another Favor.

Serpent Spawn Ambush (Melee + Athletics)

- These are nightmares made flesh—grotesque fusions of human and serpent. Their mouths drip venom that sizzles on stone. They climb walls.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** Characters with 5+ Serpent's Favor gain +1 die. Each SB adds 1 segment to Cult Ascendancy and 1 Favor.

Yara's Revelation (Presence + Insight)

- Yara is beautiful but twisted—patches of iridescent scales, vertical pupils, and a smile that's a bit too wide. Other initiates show similar changes. One girl has no eyes but points at you and whispers, "You'll change too."
- **The Twist:** Yara is not a victim. She's a volunteer. She's also not very bright—she thinks becoming a snake-person is "cool." The heroes may need to explain that this is a bad idea. Slowly. With small words.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** Characters with 7+ Serpent's Favor may sense Isoka's direct influence. They can resist (mark 1 Fatigue) or accept (gain +1 die to all rolls for the rest of the adventure). Accepting feels like drinking warm mead on a cold night—comforting and wrong.

Loot (Because Every Sword Sorcery Hero Loots)

- **Serpent's Fang:** A dagger made of black stone that whispers to you. It's very sharp and very creepy. (*+1 die to Stealth and Intimidation, deals +1 Harm. Grants 1 Serpent's Favor and +2 Corruption.*)
- **Serpent's Coil:** A rope that moves like a snake and obeys simple commands. Great for climbing, tying, or giving your companions the willies. (*+1 Corruption per session.*)

Timers Update

- City Corruption [4] → +2 segments
- Cult Ascendancy [6] → +1 segment

SESSION 3: THE SNAKE PIT (WITH ACTUAL SNAKES)

Climax Setup

The Chamber of Transformation is everything you feared and more. The ceiling disappears into shadow. The walls pulse with a heartbeat that's not human. Hundreds of cultists fill tiered seats, many already sprouting scales. At the center stands an altar carved from crystallized ichor, surrounded by bubbling pools. The air tastes of copper and ruin.

GM note: Describe this with all the purple prose you can muster. Then have a cultist trip over his robe. It keeps things from getting too grim.

The Smarter Choices (If They Think of Them)

- **Greater Good:** Embrace the transformation, become something new, then use that power to reshape the cult.

- **Heroic Stand:** Smash the altar, fight the snake-priests, and come out bloody but victorious.
- **Tactical Retreat:** Grab Yara, blow up the ichor pools, and run like hell.
- **Power Bargain:** Negotiate with Isoka for a controlled transformation—scales on your own terms.
- **Sacrifice Play:** Someone stays behind to hold the portal closed while the others escape.

Chamber of Transformation (Roll Your Best Skill)

- The room fights back: floor tiles shift, tentacles sprout from walls, a cultist's head spins around. It's a mess.
- **Isoka's Nudge:** Characters with 10+ Serpent's Favor start **Dominant**. Each SB generated gives everyone +1 Favor and +1 Corruption.

Isoka's Manifestation (Spirit + Resolve)

- She is beautiful and terrible—a serpent the size of a building, with the face of every person you've ever loved and hated. Her voice is honey and razors.
- **The Offer:** "Become my children. I will give you power beyond mortal dreams." It's a terrible deal. It's also tempting.
- **Corruption Check:** Roll Spirit + Resolve. DV = Current Corruption (max 6). Success: Gain a Transformation Talent. Failure: Isoka takes a keen interest in you. (Narrative effect, not immediate loss of character.)

Final Choice (Presence + Insight)

- The moment of decision. The chanting swells. The air crackles.
- **Serpent's Favor determines options:**
 - 0-5: Heroic Stand or Sacrifice.
 - 6-10: All but Greater Good.
 - 11+: All options.

Resolution

The aftermath tastes of copper, sweat, and victory—or bitter defeat. The city will remember the heroes, whether they want it to or not.

NEW MECHANISM: SERPENT'S FAVOR (THEY WILL NEVER SUSPECT A THING)

What It Is: A secret track the GM keeps for each character. It starts at 0. It increases when Isoka's influence touches them (via SB, certain successes, or artifact use).

What It Does: As Favor rises, the character experiences subtle luck—coincidences, good timing, strange intuitions. They think they're becoming a legendary hero. They are, but also they're becoming something else.

Serpent's Favor Effects (GM Eyes Only)

Favor	Effect (The Hero Thinks)
0-3	Nothing yet.
4-7	+1 die once per scene from "instinct."
8-12	+1 die to all rolls involving "serpent intuition."
13+	+2 dice, but civilized folk start giving you strange looks.

Corruption Score: Track separately from Favor. This is the actual transformation. Players see it. It starts at 0.

Corruption Score Effects

Score	Effects
0-5	None. Just a bit of dry skin.
6-10	Gain Serpent's Senses (+1 die to Notice in dark/underground places).
11-15	Gain Scaled Skin (+1 Armor). People start edging away from you.
16+	Gain Cosmic Insight (once per session, ask a question about cosmic threats). You also hiss your

Corruption Check: When directly facing Isoka, roll Spirit + Resolve. DV = Current Corruption (max 6). Success: Gain a Transformation Talent. Failure: The GM notes a permanent mark—a vertical pupil, a scale that won't go away, a strange hunger for raw meat.

KEY NPCs (THEY ARE NOT COMPLICATED)

Captain Marcus "The Disgraced" Dravik

Former Black Banner, current drunk with a good heart.

Tactic: Broods, then charges. Often useful.

Korvash the Iron-Blooded

Vilikari warrior with a code of honor he can't remember.

Tactic: Swings axe, says something about his ancestors, swings again.

Szik the Swift

Ykrul rogue who is far too competent to be hanging out with these people.

Tactic: Rolls his eyes, picks the lock, disappears when fighting starts.

Yara

Thinks serpent transformation is "neat" and hasn't really thought it through.

Tactic: Needs a lecture from the heroes about why becoming a snake-person might have downsides. Will be moderately disappointed.

Isoka

Cosmic entity, not entirely sure this whole cult thing was her idea.

Tactic: Monologues, offers deals, is secretly hoping someone will convince her followers to do something less messy.

LOCATIONS (WHERE SKULLS ARE CRUSHED)

The Black Goat Tavern

Not as scary as it smells.

Patrons have tiny scales you might not notice. The barmaid is a cultist but she's just in it for the dental.

Temple of the Open Sky

Definitely not a trap.

The visions are real. The headaches are also real. A helpful ghost gives cryptic advice that the heroes will misunderstand completely.

Governor's Palace

Architecture that actively hates you.

The guards are polite until they're not. A locked door can be opened with the password "hiss," which a hero might guess after standing there for ten minutes.

Chamber of Transformation

Where the snake happens.

The boss fight has phases: cultists, then serpent spawn, then Isoka's projection. The heroes will likely set something on fire. Improvise.

CULT BESTIARY (MONSTERS TO HIT)

Isokai Cultist (Cap 2)

"I have scales now. I am become death." (He is not.)

Fang Bearer (Cap 4)

The cult's version of elite troops. They regenerate 1 Harm per round. Annoying.

Serpent Spawn (Cap 3)

Grotesque fusions of human and snake. Climb walls, poison bite, no sense of humor.

Thaliss

High priest, terrible orator, has a habit of monologuing. Let the heroes interrupt him. It's fun.

RESOLUTION PATHS (HOW THEY WIN, MOSTLY)

Greater Good Victory

The heroes embrace transformation on their own terms. They become something new—serpent-touched but free. **+5 Corruption.** New cosmic allies/enemies.

Heroic Stand

The classic. Smash the altar, rally the guards, and drive out the cult. **+2 Corruption.** The city builds statues.

Tactical Retreat

They blow up the ichor pools and escape with Yara. The cult survives but suffers a major setback. **+1 Corruption.** Sequel hooks abound.

Power Bargain

They negotiate a limited transformation. Scaly patches, enhanced senses, and a new understanding of cosmic debt. **+3 Corruption.** Isoka finds them interesting now.

Sacrifice Play

One hero holds the portal closed. They die, or ascend, or simply vanish. **+10 Corruption for the fallen.** The others gain a Legendary Bond to their memory.

XP Rewards

- Greater Good: 20–25 XP
- Heroic Stand: 18–20 XP
- Tactical Retreat: 15–18 XP
- Power Bargain: 17–20 XP
- Sacrifice Play: 20–22 XP

GM TOOLKIT: RUNNING WITH A WINK**The Secret Truth (Don't Tell Them)**

Every Serpent's Favor point, every lucky break, every moment of "legendary instinct" has been Isoka's gentle push. She didn't start the cult, but she's not stopping it either. She's curious to see what happens. The real question isn't whether the heroes will change—it's whether they'll notice, and whether they'll care.

Advice for the Wise: - Let the heroes be thick. If they miss a clue, give them another. If they still miss it, have an NPC spell it out. Then have them forget and ask again. - Play up the sword sorcery tropes: sweating brows, gleaming blades, the constant need to wipe blood off everything. - When in doubt, have a cultist give a dramatic speech. The heroes can interrupt it. Let them. - The final choice should feel epic, but also a little silly. That's the tone.

CONCLUSION

"The serpent's coil tightens around the world. But heroes—even dim ones—have a way of breaking chains."

Whether they emerged as saviors or monstrous legends, the city of Midh Ahkaz will not forget the names of those who stumbled into its darkest hour. The bards will sing. The songs

will be mostly accurate. And somewhere, Isoka watches, coils patiently, and waits to see what they become next.

Now go. Let the blood flow. Let the legends begin. By Crom, they might even deserve them.